# Round 2 - 2026 Certs Concept Direction

November 2025

Round 2: 2026 Certificate Direction Concept Test - Research Plan

2026 Certs Direction Results

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## Objectives:

1. Achieve a signal on subjects to prioritize for 2026
2. Validate new AI / leader development hybrid positioning
3. Sub-objectives:
    a. Clarify difference between certs vs. MBA motivators
    b. Signal on type of instructors
    c. Competitive read of what consumers are already using to learn about AI skills / developing as a leader

## Executive Summary:

| **Key Questions and Implications** | |
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| **Question** | **Answer & Implication** |
| **Which tested subjects resonate the most?** | **<u>Positive:</u>**<br>1. Data & Decision Intelligence in the Age of AI<br>2. AI Transformation<br>3. Financial Fluency in the Age of AI<br>4. Leadership and Decision Making Under Pressure *(NSF FOR COMP)*<br>5. AI × Marketing & Growth<br>6. Lead with AI *(MICROSOFT FOR COMP)*<br>7. AI × Building Products<br>**<u>Neutral:</u>**<br>1. Gen AI Foundation for Business Productivity<br>2. Lead Teams with AI<br>3. Scaling AI Strategy *(NVIDIA FOR COMP)*<br>4. Breakthrough Innovation Strategy *(MOONSHOTS FOR COMP)*<br>5. Leading at Scale<br>**<u>Negative:</u>**<br>1. The Power of Delight<br>2. Winning Complex Deals<br>3. Negotiation and Influence |

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| | 4. AI × Creativity and Storytelling<br><br>**<u>Implications:</u>** Focus on the positive ranking subjects as portfolio priority for next year where we can. Of note, AI-oriented subjects tested more strongly than the business-oriented ones, except for high TAM subjects like NSF (Leadership and Decision Making Under Pressure). Business-oriented subjects should target similarly high TAM subjects. |
| **What positioning resonated the most?** | There was no clear winner between the three positioning statements shown: the new hybrid AI / Leadership concept (34%) vs. AI Leader (36%) vs. MBA / Business Leader (31%). Directionally, MBA-style scored lowest, indicating the portfolio / positioning should skew more AI than just traditional MBA-style.<br><br>All concepts achieved high immediate reaction, impact, relevance, and willingness to pay. Differentiation was the lowest scoring metric across all concepts. The new concept was best compared to Coursera, LinkedIn Learning, or higher education programs.<br><br>**<u>Positive feedback of new concept:</u>**<br>1. Career Advancement and Relevance: Many participants linked the program directly to advancing their careers, staying ahead, or matching professional goals.<br>2. Leadership and AI Integration: Strong repeated interest in combining leadership with AI fluency.<br>3. Expertise and Mastery in AI: Consistent desire to become an expert or master AI rather than just learn the basics.<br><br>**<u>Negative feedback of new concept:</u>**<br>1. Overly promotional or sales like tone<br>2. Lack of clarity on program connection: wanted clearer explanation of how leadership and AI integrate in practice or how outcomes would be achieved.<br><br>**<u>Implications:</u>** Both Hybrid AI / Leadership and AI Leader concepts perform best overall, driving strong preference, impact, relevance, and willingness to pay. However, to stand out, we must clearly differentiate from certificate marketplaces like Coursera or LinkedIn Learning. Consumers need proof that we can deliver true integrated growth, not just disparate AI and leadership certificates. |
| **What types of instructors do they think would be most impactful?** | **<u>AI:</u>**<br>1. AI companies / labs / think tank experts (e.g., DeepMind, OpenAI, Anthropic researchers) (44%)<br>2. Product leaders or startup operators applying AI in real-world settings (41%)<br>3. Founders or CEOs actively using AI to build or scale companies (40%)<br>4. Data or analytics leaders driving AI-powered decision-making in companies (40%)<br>5. Thought leaders or content creators who teach AI concepts in an accessible, applied way (e.g., Lenny Rachitsky, Matt Wolfe, Ben's Bites, Andrew Ng) (38%)<br><br>**<u>Developing as a Leader:</u>**<br>1. CEOs or founders known for visionary or high-impact leadership (52%)<br>2. Experienced managers or mentors who teach through real-world case studies and reflection (45%)<br>3. Executive or performance coaches specializing in influence, resilience, or creative leadership (43%) |

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| | 4. Business school professors or leadership faculty (e.g., Harvard, Wharton, Stanford) (41%)<br>5. Executive education instructors specializing in leadership and decision-making (39%)<br><br>**Implications:** For AI, credibility comes from the company they are with (big AI companies) as well as proven operators who are actively applying AI (product leaders; founders / CEOs; data leaders) and thought leaders / content creators in the space (eg Lenny's Newsletter). For developing as a leader, we see both higher level CEOs known for leadership as well as functional managers who can teach, professors, and executive coaches / instructors. |
| **What are key motivators for MBA vs. Certificate?** | **Top 5 motivators for Certs:**<br>1. Skill development - I want to build practical, job-relevant skills I can apply right away. (43%)<br>2. Career advancement - I want to accelerate my path to leadership or higher-impact roles. (40%)<br>3. Personal growth and confidence - I'm motivated by improving myself and becoming a stronger professional. (30%)<br>4. Flexibility and convenience - I need a program that fits around my professional and personal schedule. (22%)<br>5. Credibility and recognition - I want a credential from a respected institution or brand. (21%)<br><br>**Top 5 motivators for MBA:**<br>1. Skill development - I want to build stronger business, strategy, and leadership skills. (36%)<br>2. Career advancement - I want to accelerate my path to leadership or senior management. (35%)<br>3. Higher earning potential - I want to increase my long-term income and career value. (29%)<br>4. Networking opportunities - I value connecting with ambitious, like-minded professionals. (23%)<br>5. Understanding the broader business landscape - I want a more holistic understanding of how organizations operate. (22%)<br><br>**Implications:** While both certificate and MBA seekers are motivated by skill development and career advancement, these drivers are nuanced and differ. Certificate learners prioritize practical, job-ready skills they can apply immediately, seeking confidence, flexibility, and credible recognition that fit into their schedules. MBA seekers, by contrast, view their investment as long-term and strategic, focused on higher earning potential, professional networks, and deeper business acumen for long-term career growth. |
| **How are career motivated consumers already learning about AI skills?** | **Top 5 ways:**<br>1. YouTube videos or free online tutorials (56%)<br>2. Online courses (e.g., Coursera, Udemy, LinkedIn Learning) (53%)<br>3. Experimenting directly with AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Midjourney, Claude, Runway) (50%)<br>4. Employer-provided AI training or learning resources (45%)<br>5. AI-focused communities or discussion groups (e.g., Reddit, Discord, Slack) (41%)<br><br>**Top 5 providers:**<br>1. OpenAI (ChatGPT learning resources, GPTs, tutorials) (52%)<br>2. LinkedIn Learning (42%)<br>3. YouTube tutorials and creators (e.g., Matt Wolfe, AI Explained, Two Minute Papers) (41%)<br>4. Coursera (40%) |

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| | 5. Udemy (31%)<br><br>**Implications:** There are a ton of AI resources that consumers are already using, including the tools themselves to learn. We will be up against free resources and content creators / influencers in the space, as well as other online education platforms. There is also a community aspect to developing AI skills and an experimentation aspect as well. These are important aspects to keep in mind as we think about how we can differentiate our positioning from what's already out there. |
| **How are career motivated consumers already learning skills to develop as leaders?** | **Top 3 ways:**<br>1. Online courses or certificate programs (e.g., Coursera, LinkedIn Learning, MasterClass, Harvard Online) (53%)<br>2. Self-directed learning (e.g., practicing new skills on the job, reflection, journaling, feedback loops) (45%)<br>3. Employer-provided leadership development programs or resources (43%)<br><br>**Top 3 providers:**<br>1. YouTube tutorials or creators focused on developing as a leader (46%)<br>2. LinkedIn Learning (43%)<br>3. Coursera (37%)<br><br>**Implications:** Resources to develop as a leader are a bit more limited to existing courses / cert programs, self-directed learning, and employer provided learning. Similarly to AI, we will need to really differentiate + upvalue our offering to stand out against YouTube / creators and other certs offered on LinkedIn or Coursera.<br><br>Prior research supports this finding (see soft skills study here): only 3% of respondents cited soft skills as a top career barrier, the lowest of all factors tested. This suggests a low awareness of soft skills as a growth need, or a belief that they can be learned passively on the job rather than through intentional effort. |

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## Full Report

### Subjects

| | Score |
|---|---|
| Data & Decision Intelligence in the Age of AI | 15 |
| AI Transformation | 6 |
| Financial Fluency in the Age of AI | 4 |
| Leadership and Decision Making Under Pressure | 3 |
| AI × Marketing & Growth | 1 |

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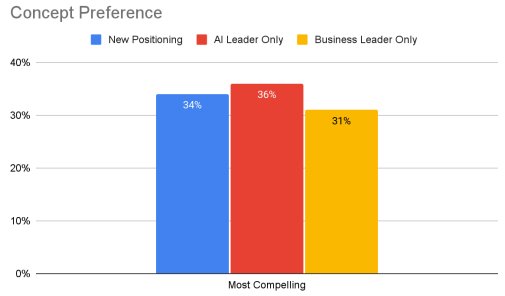
| Lead with AI | 1 |
| AI × Building Products | 1 |
| Gen AI Foundation for Business Productivity | 0 |
| Lead Teams with AI | -1 |
| Scaling AI Strategy | -1 |
| Breakthrough Innovation Strategy | -2 |
| Leading at Scale | -2 |
| The Power of Delight | -3 |
| Winning Complex Deals | -5 |
| Negotiation and Influence | -6 |
| AI × Creativity and Storytelling | -11 |

*MaxDiff Exercise: Please rank the following subjects in order of which you'd be most or least likely to purchase in order to advance your career.*

## Preference

### Concept Preference




*Based on the certificates that you're interested in and your career advancement goals, which of the following product's messages are most compelling to you?*

| | **New Blended Concept** | **AI Leader** | **Business Leader** |
|---|---|---|---|

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Positive Themes** | • Aligns with both AI expertise and career growth.<br>• Connects with goals of leading AI adoption and driving innovation.<br>• Focused on transformation and future success.<br>• Matches short- and long-term professional goals.<br>• Balances leadership foundations with modern AI fluency.<br>• Encourages mastery and visionary thinking.<br>• Viewed as valuable for current and future industry needs.<br>• Creates motivation and excitement for learning. | • Clear and detailed explanation of the program's aim.<br>• Useful and relevant skill for the age of AI.<br>• Appealing, future-focused, and innovative.<br>• Builds confidence to navigate an AI-driven world.<br>• Encourages adaptation to rapid technological change.<br>• Seen as essential for staying relevant and advancing in a career. | • Practical and applicable to real business challenges.<br>• Develops leadership, communication, and negotiation skills.<br>• Relevant for entrepreneurs and professionals seeking advancement.<br>• Builds confidence and critical thinking.<br>• Provides useful business tools and strategies.<br>• Encourages both personal and professional growth.<br>• Viewed as complete, well-rounded, and high-value. |
| **Negative Themes** | • Some felt the program's messaging came across as overly promotional or "salesy."<br>• A few questioned the real-world value of online certification.<br>• Could appear too focused on career branding rather than hands-on learning.<br>• Some wanted clearer evidence of how leadership and AI elements connect in practice. | • Some find AI-focused options intimidating.<br>• Need for more emphasis on soft skills alongside technology. | • Some found it less innovative or exciting than AI-based programs.<br>• Perceived as more traditional or conventional in focus.<br>• Could feel less distinctive or differentiated from other leadership offerings.<br>• Some wanted stronger integration of technology or modern elements. |

### Immediate Reaction / Relevance / Impact / Differentiation

1. New positioning scores very similarly to AI Leader or Business Leader; all three resonate with consumers
2. The most mentioned similar alternatives to the new positioning concept are: Coursera, LinkedIn Learning, and higher education programs.

| **T2B** | **New Positioning** | **AI Leader Only** | **Business Leader Only** |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Immediate Reaction:**<br>What is your immediate reaction to each product? | 86% | 87% | 81% |
| **Impact**<br>How impactful do each of these products feel like they could be to your professional development goals today? | 76% | 76% | 76% |
| **Relevance**<br>How relevant do each of these products feel to your professional development goals today? | 81% | 79% | 79% |
| **Differentiation**<br>Now, think about what you've seen or heard from OTHER professional development certificate programs. Compared to others, how differentiated is your preferred option's message...? | 65% | 68% | 63% |
| **Willingness to Pay**<br>Based on what you just reviewed, if you saw this message for a product offered in the real world at a reasonable price, how likely would you be to consider purchasing this service? | 92% | 91% | 95% |

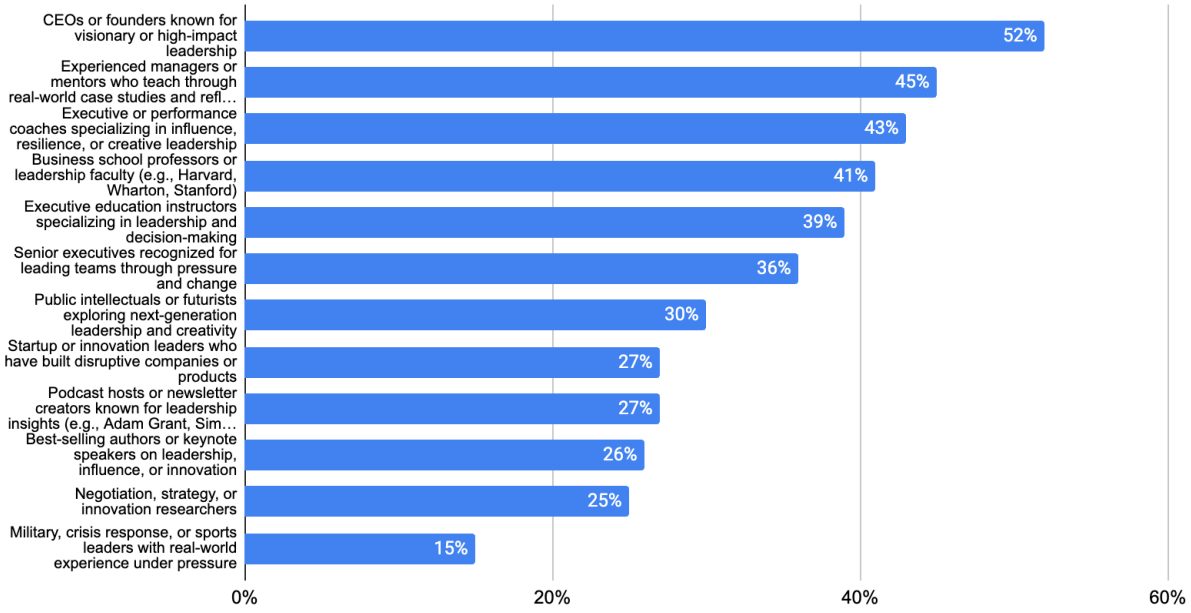
### Instructors

1. For AI, top instructors would be AI companies, product leaders or operators applying AI in the real world, founders or CEOs using AI to scale their company, data or analytics

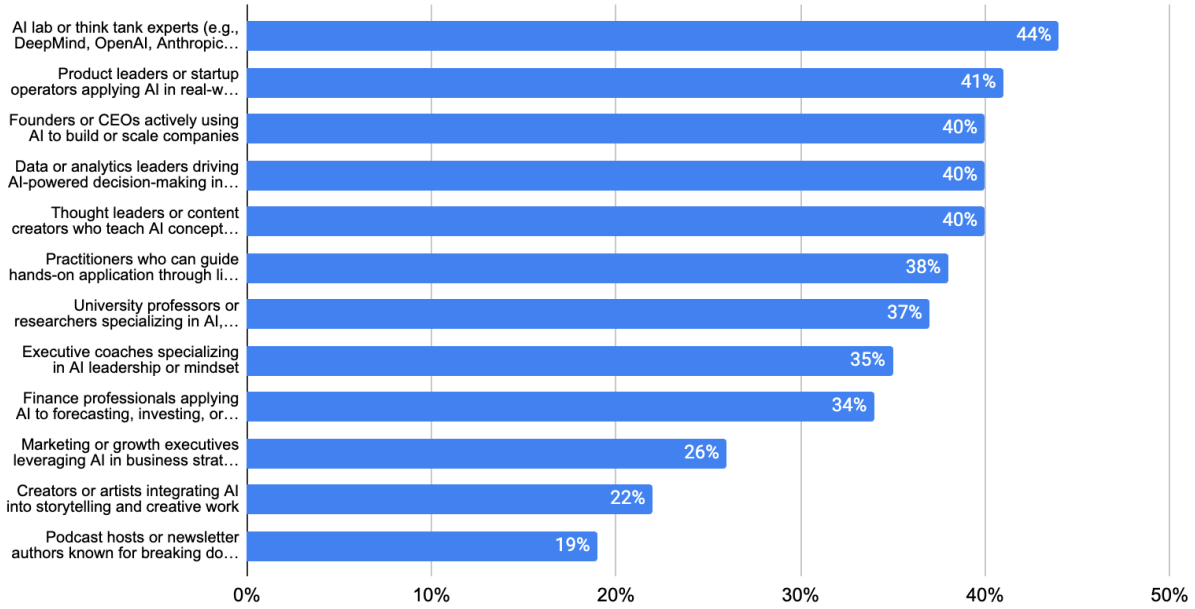
leaders driving AI-decision making, and thought leaders or content creators focused on AI.

2. For leadership development, top instructors would be CEOs or founders known for their high impact leadership, experienced managers or mentors, executive performance coaches, business school professors or faculty, and executive education instructors.

Which of the following types of instructors do you think would be most impactful for you in a course to improve as a leader, similar to the ones you ranked earlier?



Which of the following types of instructors do you think would be most impactful for you in an AI course, similar to the ones you ranked earlier?




## Competitive Resources

1. Consumers are already using multiple resources to learn about AI, with YouTube or free online tutorials ranking at the top of the list. There is no shortage of places that consumers can learn to develop AI skills today.
2. The list is more limited for those learning to develop as a leader - focused primarily on online courses, self-directed learning (like on the job), or employer-provided training. Similar to AI, YouTube or other creators stand out as a learning source.
3. We will need to pull out the value of a paid resource vs. free.

AI:

| | **When it comes to learning about AI or developing skills within AI, which of the following have you utilized, if any?** | **%** |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | YouTube videos or free online tutorials | 56% |
| 2 | Online courses (e.g., Coursera, Udemy, LinkedIn Learning) | 53% |
| 3 | Experimenting directly with AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Midjourney, Claude, Runway) | 50% |
| 4 | Employer-provided AI training or learning resources | 45% |
| 5 | AI-focused communities or discussion groups (e.g., Reddit, Discord, Slack) | 41% |
| 6 | Professional coaching, mentoring, or expert consultations | 31% |
| 7 | Workshops, bootcamps, or in-person training sessions | 29% |

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|---|---|---|
| 8 | Podcasts or newsletters about AI | 27% |
| 9 | Books or e-books about AI | 27% |
| 10 | Academic courses (college or university level) | 27% |
| 11 | I haven't utilized any resources to learn about AI | 1% |

| | **Which specific providers have you used to learn about AI or develop AI-related skills?** | **%** |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | OpenAI (ChatGPT learning resources, GPTs, tutorials) | 52% |
| 2 | LinkedIn Learning | 42% |
| 3 | YouTube tutorials and creators (e.g., Matt Wolfe, AI Explained, Two Minute Papers) | 41% |
| 4 | Coursera | 40% |
| 5 | Udemy | 31% |
| 6 | Google DeepMind | 26% |
| 7 | Reddit or Discord AI communities (e.g., Prompt Engineering groups, r/ChatGPT) | 25% |
| 8 | Harvard Business School Online | 19% |
| 9 | Anthropic (Claude learning guides) | 13% |
| 10 | NVIDIA AI Foundations | 13% |
| 11 | DataCamp | 12% |
| 12 | General Assembly | 10% |
| 13 | The Rundown AI | 8% |
| 14 | Lenny's Newsletter / Lenny's Podcast | 7% |
| 15 | Lex Fridman Podcast | 7% |
| 16 | Kaggle | 5% |
| 17 | Ben's Bites | 4% |
| 18 | Section | 3% |
| 19 | Fast.ai | 3% |
| 20 | Maven | 2% |

## Developing as a Leader:

| | **When it comes to developing your skills as a leader, which of the following resources or experiences have you utilized, if any?** | **%** |
|---|---|---|

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Online courses or certificate programs (e.g., Coursera, LinkedIn Learning, MasterClass, Harvard Online) | 53% |
| 2 | Self-directed learning (e.g., practicing new skills on the job, reflection, journaling, feedback loops) | 45% |
| 3 | Employer-provided leadership development programs or resources | 43% |
| 4 | Workshops, bootcamps, or in-person training sessions | 34% |
| 5 | Webinars, virtual panels, or live talks by leadership experts | 34% |
| 6 | Professional coaching, mentoring, or expert consultations | 33% |
| 7 | Academic courses (e.g., college or university-level leadership or management classes) | 33% |
| 8 | Podcasts or newsletters focused on leadership, management, or professional growth | 32% |
| 9 | Peer or leadership communities (e.g., Slack groups, LinkedIn groups, executive circles) | 30% |
| 10 | Books or e-books on leadership, communication, or personal effectiveness | 27% |
| 11 | I haven't utilized any resources to develop as a leader | 4% |

| | **Which specific providers have you used to develop your skills as a leader?** | **%** |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | YouTube tutorials or creators focused on developing as a leader | 46% |
| 2 | LinkedIn Learning | 43% |
| 3 | Coursera | 37% |
| 4 | Udemy | 29% |
| 5 | Professional coaching or mentoring programs | 25% |
| 6 | University or business school programs (e.g., Harvard, Wharton, Kellogg, MIT Sloan, Columbia) | 24% |
| 7 | Workshops or live bootcamps (in-person or virtual) | 23% |
| 8 | Podcasts or newsletters on developing as a leader | 23% |
| 9 | Company-sponsored leadership training | 22% |
| 10 | General Assembly | 16% |

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# APPENDIX

**Positioning Tested:**

1. **New Concept:** Online certificate programs to build, lead, and advance your career in a world re-shaped by AI. This program combines the timeless foundations of great leadership - strategy, operations, communication, and decision-making - with the modern fluency every leader now needs: how to harness the power of AI to drive innovation and performance. Together, these two dimensions prepare you to lead with confidence and impact in the age of AI.
2. **AI Leader:** Online certificate programs that will transform you into an AI expert, leader and visionary. Start as an operator (using AI effectively), evolve into an organizational leader (driving AI adoption at scale), and become a visionary who builds AI-first companies or teams. Progress through distinct stages that mirror the next decade of career growth in the AI era.
3. **Business Leader**: Online certificate programs to master the business toolkit today's leaders need to drive growth and transformation. Strengthen your ability to lead through change, influence and negotiate with impact, and make confident, data-driven decisions. Build financial acumen, sharpen strategic thinking, and manage execution under pressure. Apply proven frameworks to your role, learn directly from practitioners, and complete a capstone project that delivers measurable results.